

A.G. investigating alleged State Police traffic enforcement slowdown

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□ Former U.S. Attorney Preet Bharara will probe a reported traffic stop slowdown that followed complaints of racial bias at the State Police. (Dana DiFilippo | New Jersey Monitor)

New Jersey Attorney General Matt Platkin announced an investigation in response to a report that says New Jersey State Police’s enforcement of traffic violations plummeted after a July 2023 analysis found evidence of racial disparities in stops spanning a decade.

[The New York Times](#) on Sunday reported the number of traffic violations issued by the state police plummeted more than 60% between August and March compared to the same period last year, and that the laxer enforcement coincided with a rise in motor vehicle crashes.

“I have ordered a full investigation into how this slowdown was orchestrated, which will ensure both accountability for those involved while also protecting against such conduct occurring again in the future. That investigation is well underway,” Platkin said in a statement Wednesday.



□ Preet Bharara (Courtesy of WilmerHale)

Preet Bharara, a former U.S. attorney for the Southern District of New York, will helm the investigation as special counsel, Platkin said. Bharara was appointed because of his office's close work with the New Jersey State Police, he added.

"I have complete confidence that Mr. Bharara possesses the skill, experience, and unquestioned integrity to complete this investigation and pursue any lead, without fear or favor. To that end, while I will retain final decision-making authority, Mr. Bharara will have the full authority of my office in investigating this matter," Platkin said.

The [July 2023 report](#) found Black and Latino motorists were more likely to be stopped, have their vehicles searched, and asked to exit their vehicles between 2009 and 2021. Searches of

their vehicles were less likely to return evidence, the report found.

Beginning in 1999, the New Jersey State Police spent a decade under a consent decree to settle similar accusations of racial bias lodged by the NAACP, which this year [pushed for new leadership](#) at the law enforcement agency over doubts about their ability to rein in discrimination there.

"The safety of our residents is my top priority, and I know that the vast majority of Troopers in the State Police share my commitment to that effort," Platkin said.